

Week 1

Amazon AWS

Context

Global cloud computing and digital infrastructure provider. Millions of customers across 190+ countries and regions, offering 200+ services spanning compute, storage, databases, networking, analytics, AI, and security. FY2025 revenue approximately \$130B; consumption-based services delivered through AWS regions, availability zones, and edge locations worldwide.

Net income 2025 - \$77.7B

Operating margin 2025- 11.2%

Amazon's cloud-computing platform

Backbone

ERP + bespoke internal systems + data warehouses/lakes + BI tools + spreadsheets

Customer Accounts → Service Provisioning → Usage/Metering → Pricing → Billing → Payment → Financial Systems

- no fully unified data model yet. Single source of truth = the controlled general ledger and consolidation record for financial reporting; operational truth remains distributed across service-level systems, cost-allocation pipelines, planning tools, and spreadsheets.

Place it

AWS is clearly cloud-based and operates a globally distributed infrastructure. Its services serve many industries rather than being designed for only one vertical. AWS supports startups, enterprises, government organizations, and academic institutions across many industries.

AWS should therefore be viewed as a **Tier 1, generalist, cloud-service platform**.

Trace one flow

(O2C):

Customer creates AWS account



Valid payment method? ← DECISION POINT
(No → can't activate / Yes → account live)



Customer turns on a service

(e.g. spins up a server)



AWS tracks usage every second ← CONTROL POINT
(fact born: this usage is now recorded and owned)



End of month: AWS adds it all up



Invoice sent automatically



Payment collected automatically



Payment go through? ← DECISION POINT
(No → warning → service shut off / Yes → done)

Classify the model

AWS's model best fits the unification stance (high standardization, high integration)

Process standardization is high, they operate in the same, standardized way across geographic locations

AWS's processes are also highly integrated through customer, account, usage, security, and billing information. E.g. usage is monitored, the customer's account and permissions are verified

Name the leverage gap: Cost Allocation & Transparency

AWS automatically records usage and generates detailed billing data at scale. However, AWS documentation shows that customers must define, create, apply, and activate cost allocation tags to organize resource costs into meaningful business categories. This adds management effort and may reduce cost transparency when costs need to be attributed across teams, projects, or business units.

Week 2

Company: Sweetgreen

Breakout 1

Backbone Process: Order-to-Cash

Customer places order → Payment authorized → Order sent to kitchen → Meal prepared → Order checked/packed → Pickup or delivery → Customer receives order → Revenue captured

Order → Payment → Preparation → Quality Check → Pickup/Delivery → Complete

Lens	Value Leak	Why it matters	Thread
Frustration	Customer's order is incorrect or missing an ingredient	Customer may complain, request a remake/refund, or be less likely to return	Customer
Time	Orders pile up during lunch rush and customers wait longer than promised	Creates congestion, slows throughput, and hurts the customer experience	Customer + Operations
Cost	Incorrect orders have to be remade	Sweetgreen loses ingredients, labor time, packaging, and potentially delivery costs	Operations + Cash
Quality	Employee prepares the wrong customization or leaves out an ingredient	Reduces order accuracy and consistency	Customer + Operations

Biggest overlap: Order accuracy during preparation

This leak appears under multiple lenses.

Frustration: The customer receives something different from what they ordered.

Time: Employees have to stop and remake the meal, while the customer waits longer.

Cost: Ingredients, labor, and packaging are used twice.

Quality: The final product does not match the customer's specifications.

Threads affected

Customer + Operations + Cash

One fix that pays three times

Sweetgreen could improve the way customized orders are displayed and verified during preparation—for example, clearer digital kitchen screens or a quick final-order verification before handoff.

**Better order visibility → fewer preparation errors → fewer remakes → faster throughput
→ lower food/labor waste → happier customers**

Conclusion

The largest value leak in Sweetgreen's Order-to-Cash process is order accuracy during meal preparation. It affects Frustration, Time, Cost, and Quality while touching all three threads: Customer, Operations, and Cash. Improving order visibility and verification at the preparation stage would reduce remakes, shorten wait times, lower waste, and improve customer satisfaction.

This one is also easy to defend in class because everyone understands the process immediately, without needing specialized knowledge of the company.

Breakout 2

Leak 1 — Order accuracy during preparation

What happens: A customized salad/bowl is prepared incorrectly, an ingredient is missed, or the wrong order reaches the customer.

Why this one matters: This is where Sweetgreen's value proposition is actually delivered. Customers are paying for a **fast, customized, consistent meal**. If the physical meal doesn't match the digital order, most of the value created by the ordering experience disappears.

It hits all three threads:

Customer: dissatisfaction and lost trust

Operations: remakes and workflow disruption

Cash: wasted ingredients, packaging, labor, refunds/credits

Leak 2 — Peak-period kitchen congestion

What happens: During lunch rush, digital, delivery, and walk-in orders compete for the same kitchen capacity. Orders accumulate faster than employees can complete them.

Why this one matters: Sweetgreen's business depends heavily on throughput. A bottleneck during the most valuable hours means the company isn't just making customers wait—it is limiting how many orders the restaurant can economically fulfill.

It hits:

Customer: longer-than-promised waits

Operations: queues, employee pressure, bottlenecks

Cash: lost throughput and potentially abandoned/canceled orders

Our backbone fails to leverage at kitchen execution: Sweetgreen generates demand digitally faster than its kitchens can reliably absorb it, costing throughput, operating margin, and customer trust.

Breakout 3

Who co-designs it

The redesign must be co-designed by the frontline team members and shift managers who currently absorb the stress of the lunch rush and the frustration of remaking incorrect bowls. Because this redesign replaces manual, memory-based assembly with an event-driven, tech-enabled make-line, the people navigating the current bottlenecks must help reshape the process. They will define how fresh ingredients are prepped for the new system and how the final human touches—like adding avocado or handing off the bag—are managed without creating new queues.

The standardization tax

This redesign imposes a steep standardization tax: it strips line workers of their physical autonomy over portioning and pacing. The new system dictates the exact ingredient quantities

and the strict speed of assembly. To soften this tax, the transition must explicitly redefine their roles. By removing the repetitive stress of the assembly line, Sweetgreen can shift these workers into higher-value roles focused on culinary prep quality and front-of-house hospitality.

Rollout phasing

A progressive, phased rollout is mandatory. Implementing a fundamentally new physical and digital make-line in a "Big Bang" would make every hidden operational problem simultaneous across the company. Sweetgreen must phase the rollout by deploying the redesigned make-line in a handful of net-new store builds or retrofitting just a few high-volume urban locations first. This bounds the blast radius and proves the lift in throughput and order accuracy against the baseline before committing capital across the rest of the footprint.

The leverage case

Fund the phased rollout of a tech-enabled make-line to eliminate manual assembly errors at the source—shifting labor from repetitive portioning to hospitality, cutting peak-hour wait times, and structurally increasing throughput capacity without expanding the kitchen footprint.